Even a cursory reading will tell us that the strained relations, disagreements and failed promises largely resulted from the dire financial situation rather than any mala fide intent. It would also appear that VOC exercised his goodwill and lofty idealism to win over converts to his cause, even at a monetary loss. In the changed circumstances, his successors, especially S.D. Krishna Aiyangar, could hardly be expected to keep up to VOC's standards in spite of their undoubted personal commitment.

There were other irritants when Thevaram Pillai, the company's longstanding passenger superintendent quarrelled with the management, was dismissed, and a new one, a member of a dramatic company, appointed.[189] It is likely that tough times led to frayed tempers leading to such dismissals. There were other troubles such as fractious litigation. Writing to VOC in prison, the Colombo Agent, said: 'We have won the onion case. The Pltff's [Plaintiff's] action was dismissed with costs, but he has appealed. Although listed it is still not being argued.'[190] Such vexatious litigation added further strain.

Trouble in Colombo apart, the Bombay situation was no better. In August 1908, Damodar Soonderdas of Soonderdas Dhurumsey & Co., the Bombay Agents, arrived in Tuticorin. He spent about five weeks—staying for the most part in Tuticorin between 12 August and 16 September—before leaving for Bombay via Madras.[191] In between he also made a visit to Colombo in the first week of September.[192] According to the police, the purpose of his visit was to audit the accounts.[193] The snooping police tried to extract information from him but he dodged them when they tried to chat him up. Initially at least, the sleuth confused his name with that of his company, giving his name as 'one Damodar Chunder Das or Damodar Sunder Das or Sundara Dass Durmsey' apart from identifying him wrongly as a Bengali, with many aliases. Soon the police gathered that he was a broker in Bombay acting as SSNCo's Agent. Damodar Soonderdas had not only helped SSNCo buy the *Gallia* and the *Lawoe* but had also assisted in chartering a third steamer, the *Ipswich*. He had also sold shares for which he was entitled to 5 per cent commission. This was his first visit to Tuticorin,